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Trump backs off arms for Taiwan

Deal in jeopardy after talks with China's Xi

By Aamer Madhani,
Will Weissert and
Simina Mistreanu
ASSOCIATED PRESS

BEIJING — President Donald Trump said Friday that he has not made a decision on whether to move forward with a major arms package for Taiwan after hearing concerns about it from Chinese President Xi Jinping.

Trump's comments on Taiwan — a self-ruled island that China claims as its own territory — came as he flew back to Washington after wrapping up critical talks in which both leaders said important progress was made in stabilizing U.S.-China relations even as deep differences persist between the world's two biggest powers on Iran and Taiwan.

"I'll be making decisions," Trump said. "But, you know, I think the last thing we need right now is a war that's 9,500 miles away."

Trump's Republican administration in December authorized a record-setting \$11 billion weapons package for Taipei, but it has yet to move forward. Lawmakers also approved a \$14 billion arms sale to Taiwan in January, but the sale cannot advance until Trump formally sends it to Congress. China opposes such sales and has suggested that Washington's relationship with the self-governing island is the key factor in U.S.-China relations.

Trump said Xi also reiterated China's strong opposition to Taiwan's independence. "I heard him out," Trump said. "I didn't make a comment."

Trump's consultation with Xi about arms sales to Taiwan may violate the so-called Six Assurances, a set of nonbinding U.S. policy principles formulated in 1982 under President Ronald Reagan that have

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SAM SIANIS 1934-2026



By Rick Kogan
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

There was a time, not so very long ago, when the most famous tavern keeper in the history of this city could be found alone in the quiet, empty hours between last call and sunrise, placing chairs upside down on tables and sweeping the floor.

He was in one of the six taverns he owned, the oldest of the Billy Goat brood, on Hubbard Street tucked in perpetual twilight under Michigan Avenue.

Sam Sianis, a Greek immigrant who became one of the most successful saloonkeepers and a popular figure in the sports and media worlds, died in Endeavor Swedish Hospital in Chicago early Friday morning. He had recently had gall bladder surgery, but died of complications of old age. He was 91 years old.

"He was an inspiration and everything else to me and my siblings," said William, the eldest of Sianis' six children and the one

HE WAS THE GOAT

From 'SNL' to Cubs curse, Chicago's most famous saloonkeeper took his notoriety in stride

who has been most involved in the business with his father. "He always talked reverently about his uncle and about Greece, and he carried with him many traditions. And he loved this city passionately and became a real part of it."

Sianis' work ethic often manifested in early morning darkness, and about this cleaning time, he would say, "This is what I do. I cannot not do this. To be a manager, you have to graduate from a big college. I didn't. I graduate from mopping floors and all that. You see the work that needs to be done, you take care of that work. That is what I learn when I come here."

He came here from the tiny Greek village of PalaioPyrgos, where he was born Sotirios Athanasios Sianis in the early morning of Dec. 12, 1934. His mother, Theofana, died an hour after his birth. He was fed goat milk as an infant and raised by his father, Anthanasios, and by a large extended family that

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The Billy Goat Tavern's Sam Sianis at his famous restaurant and bar at Hubbard Street and Lower Michigan Avenue in downtown Chicago on Feb. 18. Sianis died Friday at 91 years old. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

INSIDE



JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Can't we all grill along?

White Sox fan C.J. Mendez and Cubs fan Gus Padilla grill burgers and hot dogs while tailgating before the Sox host the Cubs on Friday at Rate Field. The rivalry has a little more juice this year, as the teams will square off with both over .500 for the first time in a nonpandemic year since 2008. **City Series coverage in Sports**

One for the ages

Romeoville teenager receives his master's at Lewis University

By Allison Kiehl
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

When Benjamin Bamburac got into the car Friday to graduate from Lewis University, he didn't get behind the wheel. Because he's not old enough to drive.

At 15, Benjamin, of Romeoville, crossed the graduation stage as the university's youngest student ever to receive his master's degree from the school in its nearly 100-year tenure. His master's in computer science with a specialization in artificial intelligence became the fourth higher education degree he



Benjamin Bamburac, 15, stands in line before walking into the fieldhouse to begin Lewis University's graduation ceremony in Romeoville on Friday. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

has earned in the past five years.

Benjamin, not one to waste words, only said, "It feels great."

From a young age, parents Djordje and Sally Lou Bamburac knew that their son was special.

At just 8 months old, Benjamin Bamburac was able to read

fluently. At 5 years old, he was able to complete college-level calculus equations. So, after just one year at public school, Benjamin's parents decided to homeschool him through an online program.

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Hantavirus sparks fear, questions in a post-COVID world

By Allison Kiehl
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Brooke Loughman knows that when she opens a social media app, she'll be flooded with posts, whether she wants to see them or

not. Lately, the first-year DePaul University student has found herself scrolling quickly through her feed, trying to avoid information about hantavirus and the wave of anxiety she experiences thinking about the possibility of another

pandemic like COVID-19.

"If it is going to be a really big deal, I would rather not prematurely freak out, because if it is going to be like a COVID-19 scale thing again, I'd rather have some sense of normalcy for as long as I can," said

Loughman, who is 19.

Loughman's thoughts are echoed by students scarred by living through the coronavirus pandemic.

The fresh mix of news and misinformation about hantavirus on social media is stirring up

negative emotions for some young people, carried over from living on lockdown. COVID-era anxiety can linger and resurface, even more than half a decade after the

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